which confer local power in growth hubs like Raigad and Nashik—have stayed unfilled since.

Still, Aditi and Mahajan were picked by the state government to hoist the national flag in Raigad and Nashik on August 15. This rankled. Shinde's absence from the cabinet meet was said to be "pre-planned", attributed to a visit to Jammu and Kashmir. But he has also visited New Delhi thrice in a month.

Takeaways

- **Fadnavis rolls back Shinde policies, launches probes against his ministers**
- **Shinde and Sena minister skip a cabinet meeting**
- **Acceptance of Jarange-Patil's demand for Kunbi status for Marathas has upset NCP minister and OBC leader Chhagan Bhujbal**

In events seen as cast within a fraught dynamic, this has included meetings with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah. Shinde has always chafed at being forced to play second fiddle in the new regime, apparently in a reneging of a promise. But now he's said to be positively seething at how his wings are being clipped by the state BJP brass, including CM Devendra Fadnavis.

POINTS OF CONTENTION

Take how policies set during Shinde's tenure as CM are being rolled back. This includes the decision to hire 1,310 buses on rent for the Maharashtra State Road Transport Corporation (MSRTC). That Fadnavis has ordered a probe into the rates is galling for the ex-CM: Shinde then held charge of transport, and Gogawale chaired MSRTC. Fadnavis has twisted the knife in deep with another probe: the son of Sanjay Shirsat, the Sena's social justice minister, was alleged to have wangled a luxury hotel at cut-rate prices. With the deal called off, the Sena alleges the probe is being weaponised.

However, Shinde has a certain utility in New Delhi's eyes, according to his partisans. "He's cut from the same Hindutva cloth as them—more dependable than the TDP or the JD(U)," says a Sena source. A BJP elder concedes his marginalisation is bad optics, fostering the charge of 'use-and-throw politics'.

The Maratha stir's sudden rebirth, at that juncture, was thus freighted with meaning. Some ascribed its remote authorship to Shinde, a charge fuelled by pro-Fadnavis social media voices and even Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut. Despite the CM's artful compromise, the core dispute is alive, as is the larger politics impelling it. Do all Marathas qualify as Kunbis? Well, Shinde has once before used the stir to qualify as a 'Maratha saviour'—a useful halo for the long war. ■

RAJASTHAN

Bhajan Lal Chants the Battle Hymn

Beset by an ensemble of political and administrative challenges, the Rajasthan CM strives to build a halo



CRACKING THE WHIP Rajasthan CM Bhajan Lal Sharma

ANI

By **Rohit Parihar**

CHIEF MINISTER Bhajan Lal Sharma must have felt an awful sense of deja vu on the first two days of the monsoon session over September 1-3. The Congress was back to the unusual belligerence it has displayed of late, forcing adjournments and the like. Over the previous three sessions, the BJP government had struggled to own the narrative. Sharma's ministers—many first-timers among them—faltered before the blitz. Even senior BJP men allowed themselves a jibe or two.

Erasing the sense of authority deficit is thus a vital task for the CM. The marathon sessions he held over August 25-26 with MLAs and MPs was part of that. Politically, his strategy also reveals his anxieties. It's the classic tool in the hands of any CM: dangling the prospect of a cabinet reshuffle. High time too. For, carrying flaky debutants while a sullen cohort of veterans sits out—due to their proximity to ex-CM Vasundhara Raje—is breeding disaffection. And nothing like the love of a good berth to keep incumbents as well as wannabes in a complaisant mood. Yet, too much deference to Raje loyalists will seem weak-kneed. He has to move carefully.